



12th Grade English Language Arts — The Enduring Quest

English 4 (Florida course 1001400) · Full year, delivered as two semester sections · What endures when the world ends? What does it mean to be human? How do we flourish?

~4¼ hrs
per week
50 min/day, M–F

About this overview. This document is an example of how the course might be taught. More books are approved for this course than appear here (the approved list also includes works such as *1984*, *The Fellowship of the Ring*, *The Road*, and *Invisible Man*), so scholars may see some variation in texts and projects from course to course, and between the live school and On-Demand. Each teacher also leans into their own strengths and passions; the structure, expectations, and time commitment below are representative of the course as designed.

The senior year of ELA takes up the questions that have occupied human thought across centuries and cultures. Scholars begin with the great wisdom traditions, reading the Bhagavad Gita, the Bible, Confucius, Buddhist parables, the Qur'an, Plato, and Aristotle on what it means to live well. The year then carries those ancient questions into modern literature: *Frankenstein* and Nietzsche on who decides what is good, *Heart of Darkness* with Marcus Aurelius and Emerson on what endures in the dark, and *The Metamorphosis* on what makes us human. Scholars read primary texts directly on the lesson pages, write weekly, and build a substantial project each module. As seniors, they also propose a capstone app and learn to work judiciously with AI.

THE YEAR AT A GLANCE — 4 MODULES · ~35 WEEKS

Module · Guiding question	Weeks	Quarter	Texts & module project
1 · Ancient Wisdom — How should we live?	10	Q1	Bhagavad Gita, the Bible, Confucian Analects, Buddhist parables, the Qur'an, Plato (Ring of Gyges, the Cave), Aristotle's <i>Ethics</i> ; "How to Live Well" synthesis essay drawing on at least four traditions + a VR "Meet the Thinkers" gallery presentation
2 · The Creature and the Creator — Who decides what is good?	9	Q2	<i>Frankenstein</i> (5 weeks) and carefully framed Nietzsche selections (2 weeks); opens with the senior capstone proposal ; closes with a menu project in the scholar's chosen format
3 · Into the Dark — What endures in the dark?	8	Q3	<i>Heart of Darkness</i> (with its critical reception studied after the reading), Marcus Aurelius' <i>Meditations</i> , Emerson's "Self-Reliance," poems by Hopkins, Housman, and Donne; synthesis week + menu project
4 · What makes us human?	8	Q4	<i>The Metamorphosis</i> , poems by Herbert, Blake, and Dickinson ("Hope is the thing with feathers"); synthesis week + final menu project

A TYPICAL WEEK

When	What the scholar does (~50 min/day)
Mon–Wed	Three literature lessons : the reading is embedded on the page, taught with interactive activities and historical context.
Thu	A combined grammar & vocabulary lesson : a practical writing skill (semicolons, parallelism, concision, integrating quotations) plus vocabulary from the week's text.
Fri	Project Day : the week's Quick Write is submitted and the module project moves a step forward; Fridays also leave time to push the senior capstone ahead.
Flexible	Two short solo VR activities step inside the week's text or build the project, on Optima's VR campus.

TIME COMMITMENT

250 minutes per week, the standard planning figure for Optima high-school courses: about 50 minutes a day, Monday through Friday. Reading and writing are the core of that time. **Project weeks** at the end of each module can run longer.

THE MODULE PROJECT MENU

- For Modules 2–4 the scholar **chooses a format**: essay, disputatio, journal/diary, VR experience, short film/screenplay, or podcast/oration
- Across the year at least one pick must be **multimedia with a recorded spoken component** and at least one must be **argument-driven**
- Projects are built gradually every Friday, never in one sitting, and graded on a shared rubric with format-specific craft criteria

THE SENIOR CAPSTONE & AI

- Early in Module 2, each senior **proposes an app** that contributes meaningfully to society, arguing why it matters in light of the wisdom traditions studied in Module 1
- The proposal is written in this course; the app itself is **built in other courses** using the scholar's school Claude account
- The course teaches **judicious AI use**: prompting well, keeping a prompt library, and knowing where the scholar's own judgment and voice are required

WHAT SCHOLARS NEED

- A computer with a web browser; all readings are public-domain texts embedded directly on the lesson pages
- VR headset** for Optima's VR campus and a **microphone** for recorded presentations
- OneDrive (Microsoft 365) for the Learning Log, Quick Writes, and project documents

NOTES FOR FAMILIES

On-Demand (asynchronous). This course is designed for self-paced study with due dates for pacing. A teacher is available throughout for support, feedback on writing, and grading.

Live school. Scholars enrolled in the live school complete the same course in VR every school day with a teacher and classmates.

A note on the readings. Scholars read sacred and philosophical texts from many traditions, presented historically and respectfully, and challenging modern authors (Nietzsche, Conrad) taught with careful critical framing. The aim throughout is the classical one: to read well, weigh honestly, and arrive at a considered answer of one's own.